The History of the Class of 1984

The World/Nation/State/University

The class of 1984 had expectations that few graduation classes experienced - the gloom and doom from George Orwell's *1984*. Orwell's vision of 1984 was one of dictators, dehumanization, electronic surveillance and perpetual war. Fortunately, this dark and gloomy view of the future was far from reality even though there was a terrorist explosion which killed 241 U.S. troops in Beirut, Lebanon, and the United States quelled an uprising in Grenada.

Nationally, Ronald Reagan had just been elected to his second term as the President of the United States by defeating Walter Mondale with 525 electoral votes, more than any other presidential candidate in the nation's history. On the economic front, rapid inflation had ended, unemployment had fallen, and the economy had made a strong recovery and was thriving. However, budget deficits reached record levels. The government mandated the breakup of AT&T into three companies: local service, equipment, and long distance. Cabbage Patch Kids were popular with both the young and old. In the sports world, Georgetown won the NCAA Basketball Championship; the Boston Celtics won the NBA Championship with Larry Bird winning the MVP; the Oakland Raiders beat the Washington Redskins in Superbowl XVII; the Olympics were held in Los Angeles where thirteen countries (including the Soviet Union, East Germany, Bulgaria, Cuba, and Hungary) boycotted the games. In science, the first jet-powered backpacks were used in space and Sally Ride became the first American woman in space. The most popular movies were *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom*, *Ghostbusters,* and *Beverly Hills Cop*.

In the state of Virginia, both chambers of the Virginia General Assembly passed a bill that raised the legal age for drinking alcohol from 19 to 21. However, Governor Charles Robb's, *Task Force to Combat Drunk Driving* recommended anyone caught driving with a blood-alcohol level of 0.10 or higher would be automatically guilty, while the House wanted automatic convictions of motorists driving with a 0.15 blood-alcohol level. Governor Robb preferred the stricter methods of enforcement rather than increasing the drinking age again.

In Blacksburg, the Blacksburg Transit (BT) System started with eight buses with drivers earning $3.35 per hour. William Lavery was the president of Virginia Tech and the university was continuing its rapid growth in enrollment with approximately 25,000 students. Shortages of classrooms, laboratory and office space were being alleviated. Under President Lavery, SAT scores requirements were increased, a University Core Curriculum was established and research was a major emphasis of the university. Engineering students were required to purchase personal computers for the first time. The IBM PC Jr., also known as the "Peanut" was a popular choice. The student discount allowed a student to pay about $200 per quarter for two years. Other popular PCs were the IBM PC and IBM PC-XT. In sports, the Hokies' Men's baseball team went 34-14. The basketball team's record was 23-13, beating defending national champion N.C. State. The Hokie team finished 3rd in the NIT. In football, the Hokies went 9-2 but were left out of the bowl lineup. However, defensive tackle Bruce Smith was named to the Kodak All-America football team.

The German Club Experience

I became familiar with the German Club during my sophomore year through my hometown friend, Rick Renz. Rick and I had played baseball together in Collinsville, VA, and he was a current member of the Club. We discussed the German Club, its focus on services and Rick's personal experiences. I was not interested in fraternities but liked providing services for others and wanted to pursue joining the German Club. During 1984, the only way to become a member was to have a Club member sponsor you during a prospective quarter. The sponsors were responsible for introducing the prospective to the Club and assisting him with any issues that may arise during the quarter. Prior to becoming invited to be a prospective member of the Club, one had to have an interview with three current Club members. I remember being anxious prior to the interview and I still remember questions regarding my definition of "Aim" and "Earnestness." After the interviews, there was a 'Prospective Party,' an informal gathering enabling Club members and prospective members to get to know one another.

There were some unique aspects to the Prospective Quarter, which I viewed as very positive. The first was that the process offered a chance for the prospectives to examine the Club as well as for the Club to examine the prospectives. In addition to this joint evaluation, a prospective was allowed to participate in all Club activities, with the exception of the weekly business meetings, so that he could obtain a full understanding of the German Club's purpose. During the quarter, the prospective class was responsible for hosting a party for the members at the Manor. The purpose of the party was to assess the prospectives' hosting abilities as well as provide a social setting for the members to become better acquainted with the prospectives. Our party had a "Wild, Wild West" theme and our entertainment consisted of a skit with Ma, Pa, and their children: Red, Fred, Ned, and Zed. It was about as "corny" as it could get, but I recently met one of my closest friends, Wayne Clarke, for dinner in New Hampshire (over twenty years after our Prospective Party) and we (and our families) had a good laugh remembering how silly Wayne looked as 'Ma!' (Of course, I was 'Pa' so it did not say much for my taste either!)

During the quarter, the Club members discussed the prospectives during each business meeting. Two formal 'Knock" sessions were held in which a prospective could be dismissed ('knocked'.) If "Knocked" the prospective would be informed that they would not be offered membership to the Club and the prospective process for that individual came to an end. After surviving the final "Knock" session, a prospective would be informed that he had the opportunity to become a full member of the Club. This was a very joyous occasion for all new members and culminated in a 'Candlelight Induction Service' that was held at War Memorial Chapel.

Dances

During 1983, the Club began hosting only a winter quarter dance during the academic year for the Virginia Tech student body. It was known as Virginia Tech's Mid-Winter Dance. The theme for 1984 was 'Pink Champagne', which was meant to represent the spirit of the 1920s. The dance was held on Friday and Saturday, February 3/4, from 8:00 until midnight, in the Commonwealth and Old Dominion Ballrooms at Squires Student Center. It was the first time the German Club decorated both ballrooms and the lobby. On Friday night, the *Tams* played mostly beach music and top 40 hits. Dress was semi-formal. In order to overcome a lack of interest in previous years, Saturday night was optional black tie to complement Homecoming in the fall and Ring Dance in the spring. *The Tommy Dorsey Orchestra* played Big Band music on Saturday night. Tickets were $20 per couple for both nights in advance, $22 at the door, or $13 for one night or $15 at the door. Over 2,000 people attended. For Midwinters, the German Club brought back the tradition of wearing the purple ribbons across their tuxedo shirts to signify Club membership. The guests were then able to identify their hosts for any assistance.

The Dance committee was headed by Byrum Geisler with Paul Darrah as Chair of Decorations, Hollis Harrel and Paul Eithner – Favors, Dough Harrison – Publicity, Steve Laviinder – Tickets, Jim Hicks – Cleanup. Publicity included posters, flyers, buttons, door slips, tent cards, an obelisk on campus, radio announcements, and banners on campus buildings, a showcase in Squires, and an extended slide show, which was delivered to other organizations. A Pancake Breakfast was held the Sunday before the dance at the Days Inn and cost $2.49 for all-you-can-eat. Bob Brown won the "Pork Award" at the pancake breakfast. The German Club spent $12,089 on the dance and received ticket sales of $10,050 for a net loss of $2,039. A $2,000 loss was anticipated and was covered by program sales and other revenue. After the dance on Saturday night, there was a party for Club members and their dates. The party started around 1:30 a.m. and lasted for several hours. It was an opportunity to blow off steam and relieve the stresses incurred over the busy week.

Service Activities and Accomplishments

In addition to the dances, the German Club was very busy with other services activities. These activities included:

- Providing the manpower for the different craft shows in Blacksburg, including the YMCA Craft Fair, the Blacksburg Junior Commerce Congress Antique Show, and the Voluntary Action Center (VAC) Brush Mountain Crafts Fair.

- Working with nine of the Virginia Tech Union (VTU) Broadway shows (that were performed at Squires) as the stage crew to unload, setup, strike and reload the sets and scenery. This allowed the VTU to forego paying a union crew and allowed patrons who could not afford to see the shows to do so. For example, a show that cost $15 per ticket in Richmond only cost $5 per ticket at Tech (even lower for students.) Also, the German Club broke set-up and strike records for most shows. The shows worked by Club members included *Oliver,* the New World Ballet, Lausanne Orchestra, *Pump Boys and Dinettes*, Caracas Ballet, *Crimes of the Heart*, *Agnes of God*, *Joseph and His Amazing Technicolor Dreamcoat,* and *Mummenshanz*.
- Serving as the Arrangements Committee for the YMCA Hunger Hike project.

Providing meeting space via the German Club Manor for the Provost, Deans, and other university officials. These meetings were conducted on the average of twice a week.

- Selling programs at sporting events and received over $3,600 for the German Club from the sales.
- Organizing the annual Christmas Party for the underprivileged children of the area.
- Providing manpower for the Voluntary Action Center Cheese Distribution for needy families and Blacksburg High School Invitational Track Meet.
- Cutting wood for the APO Service Day.
- Hosting the Neighborhood Christmas Sing-a-long.

The German Club was very well respected within the student body and several members were recognized throughout the year with various awards and recognition. Accomplishments of Club members included:

- The Regimental Staff of the Corp of Cadets included Greg Daniels as Regimental Executive Officer, Scott Pearl as Group Executive Officer, Paul Geithner as the Operations Officer, and James Hicks as Battalion Commander.
- Wayland Hundley was the 1984 Class President.
- Mike Watts, John Davis, and Mark Traband were inducted into Omicron Delta Kappa (ODK.)
- Greg Daniels and Dan Goulson made *Who's Who of College Students.*
- Jim Stroh, '85 was selected as the very first student representative to the Virginia Tech Board of Visitors and was the Vice-President of the Student Government Association.
- Dan Goulson was the second student representative to the Virginia Tech Board of Visitors and was the President of ODK.

German Club officers for 1984 were President – Joe Thomas, Executive Vice-President – Dan Goulson, Secretary – Doug Boston, Treasurer – Andy Rector, Leader – Tyrone Lam, Vice-President Membership – Chris Ferrante, Vice-President Facilities – Greg Marzullo, Alumni Secretary – Tripp Dunman, and Historian – John Blauvelt. Throughout the year, the Club members met in McBryde Hall on Monday evenings from 7:00 until 9:00 (and usually later.) Some of the improvements our class provided to the Club included basketball goals and lines on the outdoor court, a Bumper Pool table and drink vending machine in the Manor.

During my junior and senior years at Virginia Tech, I became very involved with the German Club as the Programs Chairman, maintained the grounds during the summer, served as Recruiting Chairman and Elections Chairman, helped assemble the German Club Alumni Directory, and assisted with the many service projects throughout these years. The German Club was, and still is, very special to me. I have made many friends in the Club and continue to cherish these friendships today. The 'Ritual' is still an important part of my life and is proudly displayed in my home in Raleigh, North Carolina.

Even though 1984 had quite an onerous supposition based on Orwell's novel, it turned out to be a very successful and prosperous year for the German Club Class of 1984. Our 1984 Classmates were:

Bentley, Michael D.	Harrell, Hollis A.	Quinn, James E.
Blauvelt, John James	Harrison, Douglas E.	Rector, Roy A., Jr.

Blount, Alston W., III
Carroll, James N.
Connell, William Tod
Cryer, Robert D.
Daniels, Gregory Lee
Ferrante, Christopher M.
Geithner, Paul H.
Hadra, W. Reed
Hicks, James W., Jr.
Hochella, John S.
Hundley, Wayland E.
Kingma, Stanley David
Lam, Victor Tyrone
Lavinder, Steven Robert
Marzullo, Gregory D.
Pearl, Scott M.
Schudel, Robert E.
Shelton, Clifford L.
Shook, Brian T.
Slaughter, James Wacho
Stewart, Victor Lynn
Thomas, Joseph C., Jr.
Varner, Steven T.
Wright, John David

Prepared by:
James Wacho Slaughter, '84